

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Education Administration English

Conversation lab

8 complete workplace dialogues, followed by eight additional role-play cases. Study the exchanges, then make the conversation your own.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Find the right language. Speak, write, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For school administrators, curriculum coordinators, student-services staff, program directors, admissions teams, registrars, and education operations leaders.

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Inside this conversation lab

Original fictional training conversations in professional English. These are realistic scripts, not transcripts of actual people. The professional roles are the speaker labels; all figures, incidents, and organizations are invented.

01 Enrollment capacity

02 A student support handoff

03 Curriculum scheduling conflict

04 A parent communication correction

05 Faculty workload planning

06 Student-record request

07 Accreditation program review

08 Budget priorities

Then try eight independent role-play cases, followed by feedback criteria and references.

Read it. Hear it. Make it yours.

1. Read the setting. Identify the roles, the immediate problem, and what each speaker needs.
2. Read the whole conversation aloud with a partner. In a group, give a third person the observer role. For three-speaker scripts, assign each professional a separate voice.
3. Notice how the speakers ask a specific question, qualify a claim, disagree, explain a technical point, or agree on a next step. Underline language you would actually use.
4. Cover the script. Recreate the exchange using the situation and professional roles. Keep the meaning, but change the wording.
5. Switch roles and introduce a complication: a missing record, a different priority, an unavailable colleague, or a changed assumption. End with a clear outcome or unresolved question.

Register and terminology

These colleagues use concise professional language. In an internal technical meeting, familiar abbreviations can be natural. With a new colleague or a client, expand unfamiliar terms and check understanding. Keep disagreement directed at the evidence or proposal, and match the degree of certainty to what is known.

Independent study

Speak each role aloud. Pause before the reply and supply your own response before revealing the next line. Record a second version using invented details, then compare its clarity and tone with the script.

Professional context

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

FULL DIALOGUE 01 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Enrollment capacity

A school team reviews applications for a full program.

Roles: Admissions coordinator / Program director

Admissions coordinator: We have twelve eligible applicants and eight available places. How should we handle the remaining four?

Program director: Apply the published admissions criteria and waitlist process consistently. Don't invent a new priority rule.

Admissions coordinator: Two families have asked whether an informal recommendation guarantees a place.

Program director: Clarify that it doesn't. Explain the documented process and available review route.

Admissions coordinator: I'll verify the capacity figure and prepare consistent notices.

Program director: I'll review them for accuracy before they go out.

Notice the professional language

admissions criteria - The stated requirements used to assess applications for entry to a program.

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 02 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

A student support handoff

Staff coordinate a student's support referral.

Roles: Student services coordinator / Academic adviser

Student services coordinator: The referral was submitted, but the student says nobody has contacted them.

Academic adviser: I can check receipt through the approved system. What follow-up was promised?

Student services coordinator: A contact from the support team, but no named owner was recorded.

Academic adviser: I'll ask that team to acknowledge the referral and confirm responsibility.

Student services coordinator: I'll explain the next step to the student without sharing unnecessary sensitive details.

Academic adviser: Record the contact and any unresolved barrier so the referral doesn't disappear between teams.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "I can check receipt through the approved system. What follow-up was promised?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 03 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Curriculum scheduling conflict

Two departments need the same teaching space.

Roles: Timetabling officer / Department chair

Timetabling officer: Both labs are scheduled for Wednesday afternoon, but only one suitable room is available.

Department chair: Our course requires the specialist equipment. Does the other course need it too?

Timetabling officer: Only for two sessions. I can explore a room swap for the remaining weeks.

Department chair: Check instructor availability and student conflicts before confirming it.

Timetabling officer: I'll produce options with the affected sessions clearly marked.

Department chair: We'll review them against learning requirements rather than simply allocate the room to the first request.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "Our course requires the specialist equipment. Does the other course need it too?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 04 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

A parent communication correction

A school corrects an inaccurate assessment notice.

Roles: School administrator / Year coordinator

School administrator: Our notice says results are final, but moderation hasn't finished.

Year coordinator: We need to correct that promptly. The marks are provisional until the review is complete.

School administrator: Should we wait and explain it only if parents ask?

Year coordinator: No. Send a clear correction to the same audience and explain the actual status.

School administrator: I'll draft the correction and confirm the expected update date.

Year coordinator: I'll verify the wording with the assessment lead before distribution.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "Should we wait and explain it only if parents ask?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 05 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Faculty workload planning

A department discusses an additional section.

Roles: Department chair / Scheduling administrator

Department chair: Can we add another section using the current teaching allocation?

Scheduling administrator: Not without reviewing contact hours, preparation, and the existing workload agreements.

Department chair: Enrollment demand is higher than expected. What options can we assess?

Scheduling administrator: Additional staffing, a revised timetable, or a different section size within applicable limits.

Department chair: I'll confirm the instructional requirements and available budget.

Scheduling administrator: Then we can compare feasible options and obtain the required approval before advertising the section.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "Can we add another section using the current teaching allocation?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 06 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Student-record request

An outside organization requests a student list.

Roles: Registrar / Privacy coordinator

Registrar: A partner wants a list of students and their grades for recruitment. Can I send it?

Privacy coordinator: We need to review the purpose, authority, and applicable student-record rules before disclosure.

Registrar: They say another department shared something similar last year.

Privacy coordinator: That doesn't establish permission for this request. Ask for the specific fields and intended use.

Registrar: I'll route it through the approved review and hold the export.

Privacy coordinator: I'll confirm the permitted response and any consent or other requirements that apply.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "A partner wants a list of students and their grades for recruitment. Can I send it?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 07 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Accreditation program review

A program team compares evidence with a stated outcome.

Roles: Program director / Quality officer

Program director: The self-study says every graduate meets this outcome. Our evidence covers only one cohort.

Quality officer: Then the claim needs narrowing or more evidence. How was that cohort assessed?

Program director: A common rubric, but scoring consistency hasn't been reviewed.

Quality officer: Describe those limits and include the moderation plan.

Program director: I'll link the assessment evidence to the outcome and identify the remaining gaps.

Quality officer: Good. An accurate improvement plan is more credible than a stronger claim the records can't support.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "Then the claim needs narrowing or more evidence. How was that cohort assessed?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 08 / 6 SPEAKING TURNS

Budget priorities

An administrator evaluates competing funding requests.

Roles: Finance manager / School leader

Finance manager: The requests exceed the available budget by \$30,000. Which costs are essential this year?

School leader: Staffing for the existing program is essential. The equipment upgrade has options.

Finance manager: Separate replacement needs from desirable enhancements and include ongoing costs.

School leader: I'll ask each team to explain the educational impact of deferral.

Finance manager: We'll compare those impacts using the same budget assumptions.

School leader: Then I'll bring a prioritized proposal to the decision group, with the tradeoffs explicit.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "The requests exceed the available budget by \$30,000. Which costs are essential this year?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

Eight more situations to make your own

The following cases are open role plays. They give you facts, contrasting roles, useful expressions, and a short model response. Use what you learned from the complete dialogues to create a longer exchange.

Preparation: two minutes. Conversation: three to five minutes. Feedback: one minute. Switch roles and repeat with the second-round challenge.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 01

Enrollment, Admissions, and Placement

SHARED CASE

A family asks why an applicant was not offered a place. The administrator needs to explain the published process without discussing other applicants.

Role A | Responding professional

Clarify missing information before responding. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

Useful expressions

When you say ..., do you mean ...?

Could you clarify which ...?

So, my understanding is Is that right?

Cover this until after your first attempt

I can explain the published criteria and the next steps available for this application. Which part of the decision notice would you like me to clarify? I cannot discuss another applicant's record.

Second round

The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 02

Curriculum Planning and Learning Outcomes

SHARED CASE

A curriculum plan lists topics but no observable learning outcomes. Teachers disagree about what an assessment should measure.

Role A | Responding professional

Explain a useful distinction in plain English. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You are unfamiliar with one technical term in the case. Ask for a plain-English explanation and then paraphrase it. Do not pretend to understand a term you cannot explain.

Useful expressions

In this context, ... means

The difference is that

How would you explain that distinction to a colleague?

Cover this until after your first attempt

A topic says what we cover; an outcome says what learners should be able to do. Let's define those performances first, then check whether the assessment gives learners a chance to demonstrate them.

Second round

Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 03

Student Support and Intervention

SHARED CASE

A support meeting has attendance information but no record of which interventions have already been tried.

Role A | Responding professional

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You can help but need a clear request and its purpose. Ask what is required and whether the timing is fixed or negotiable.

Useful expressions

Could you provide ... so that ...?

Please confirm ... by [agreed time].

If that timing is not possible, please let me know

Cover this until after your first attempt

Could you bring the relevant attendance pattern and the support actions already attempted? We can use those records to plan the discussion and avoid repeating an approach without reviewing its effect.

Second round

The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 04

Parent and Guardian Communication

SHARED CASE

A guardian says an email sounded accusatory. The school intended to request a meeting about repeated late arrivals.

Role A | Responding professional

Acknowledge a communication problem and give a corrected message. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You are frustrated because an earlier message created an expectation. Explain that expectation. Ask your partner to distinguish the correction from anything still uncertain.

Useful expressions

My earlier message did not make ... clear.

I'm sorry for The correct information is

Let me check that the revised explanation addresses

Cover this until after your first attempt

I'm sorry the wording sounded accusatory. The purpose is to understand the late arrivals and discuss support. Could we arrange a time to review the pattern and hear your perspective?

Second round

The listener remains disappointed after the correction. Acknowledge the impact and restate the available next step calmly.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 05

Faculty Coordination and Evaluation

SHARED CASE

Two teachers use different interpretations of the same grading rubric. Students receive inconsistent explanations.

Role A | Responding professional

Describe observed behavior, its effect, and a useful next step. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You can explain a practical obstacle affecting the work. Share it after your partner asks for your perspective, then agree on one observable change.

Useful expressions

In [specific situation], I noticed

The effect was What was happening from your perspective?

Could we agree to ... and review it ...?

Cover this until after your first attempt

Let's compare the descriptors against the same sample of work. Where do our interpretations differ? We can agree on clearer explanations and examples before using the rubric again.

Second round

The recipient disagrees with your interpretation. Return to the observed example, listen, and revise an unsupported assumption.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 06

Compliance, Records, and Privacy

SHARED CASE

A colleague asks for an entire student file for a narrow administrative task. The authorized scope is unclear.

Role A | Responding professional

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You can help but need a clear request and its purpose. Ask what is required and whether the timing is fixed or negotiable.

Useful expressions

Could you provide ... so that ...?

Please confirm ... by [agreed time].

If that timing is not possible, please let me know

Cover this until after your first attempt

Could you identify the purpose and the specific records needed? Let's confirm the permitted access and sharing process before providing information from the file.

Second round

The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 07

Accreditation and Program Review

SHARED CASE

A program review action plan lists five actions. Three are complete, one is underway, and one has no assigned owner.

Role A | Responding professional

Distinguish completed work from pending work and explain its impact. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You need to brief someone who has only one minute. Ask what is complete, what is open, and which open item affects the next action.

Useful expressions

We have completed ...; ... remains open.

As of ..., the status is

The next update will cover

Cover this until after your first attempt

Three actions are complete and one is underway. The fifth needs an owner and a target date. I'll make that outstanding decision visible in the program review update.

Second round

The listener asks you to reduce the update to two sentences. Preserve the most important completed and pending items.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 08

Budget, Staffing, and Institutional Priorities

SHARED CASE

A department can open another class by reallocating staff or hiring temporary support. Each option affects workload differently.

Role A | Responding professional

Compare options using the same criteria and state the tradeoff. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You favor one option but have not checked whether the scope is comparable. Ask about one difference, then explain the tradeoff you are willing to accept.

Useful expressions

Both options ..., but

Option A ..., whereas option B

The comparison depends on

Cover this until after your first attempt

Reallocation uses existing staff but changes their workload; temporary support adds cost and preparation needs. Let's compare the implications for learners and staff before choosing an option.

Second round

Your listener focuses only on the lowest price or fastest date. Explain one other relevant comparison criterion.

Debrief

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

Give feedback that helps

Score each criterion 0, 1, or 2. This is a practice rubric, not a professional qualification or CEFR test. Do not award or remove points for a particular accent.

Meaning and accuracy

Keeps the case facts accurate; clearly separates confirmed and unknown information.

Clarity and language

Uses understandable sentences and explains specialist terms when the listener needs it.

Interaction and tone

Responds to the other person's question, checks understanding, and uses an appropriate tone.

Task completion

Makes the requested action or unresolved question clear without inventing authority or facts.

Use the same scale for each criterion

0 - Not yet: The reader or listener cannot yet recover the intended meaning or action.

1 - With support: The message works after a prompt, clarification, or revision.

2 - Independently: The message is clear and accurate without a prompt.

Feedback sequence

First, identify a successful phrase. Next, identify one point where meaning or accuracy needs work. Offer one useful language correction, allow a repeat, and compare the two attempts. A total out of eight describes this performance only; do not translate it into a proficiency level.

Final challenge

Choose a case not rehearsed today. The learner gives a one-minute response, answers two follow-up questions, and writes a 70-110 word message. Add the lesson's second-round challenge. Compare the result with an earlier attempt using the four criteria.

Use the language responsibly

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

US Department of Education: FERPA

<https://studentprivacy.ed.gov/ferpa>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.